

# Academic Writing (BETA)

## Seminar 2



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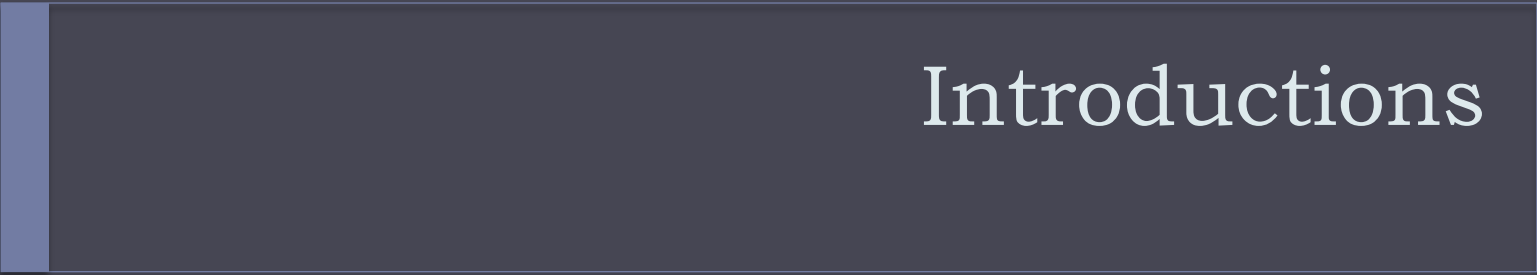
# Today's Programme

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- ▶ Introductions
- ▶ Error correction: *Grammar issues*



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# Introductions

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# General structure of introductions in science papers

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|   |                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|---|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | Establish the importance of your field<br>Provide background facts/information<br>Define the terminology in the title/key words<br>Present the problem area/current research focus |
| 2 | Previous and/or current research and contributions                                                                                                                                 |
| 3 | Locate a gap in the research<br>Describe the problem you will address<br>Present a prediction to be tested                                                                         |
| 4 | Describe the present paper                                                                                                                                                         |



# Most basic introduction structure

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▶ Three sentences:

1. General indication of topic/factual observation
2. Narrowing down to a subtopic/indicating a problem
3. Thesis statement



## General indication of topic

*In recent years, many studies have been published on the use and influence of social media.*

## Narrowing down to a subtopic

*One of the aspects that has been studied is the effect of social media on psychological well-being of teenagers.*

## Thesis statement

*In fact, there is strong evidence that social media have a negative influence on teenagers' self-esteem.*

## Observation or fact

*In recent years, the number of Facebook users has increased drastically.*

## Narrowing down to a subtopic

*However, there are rising concerns about the privacy of Facebook users.*

## Thesis statement

*How can the data of Facebook users be protected?*

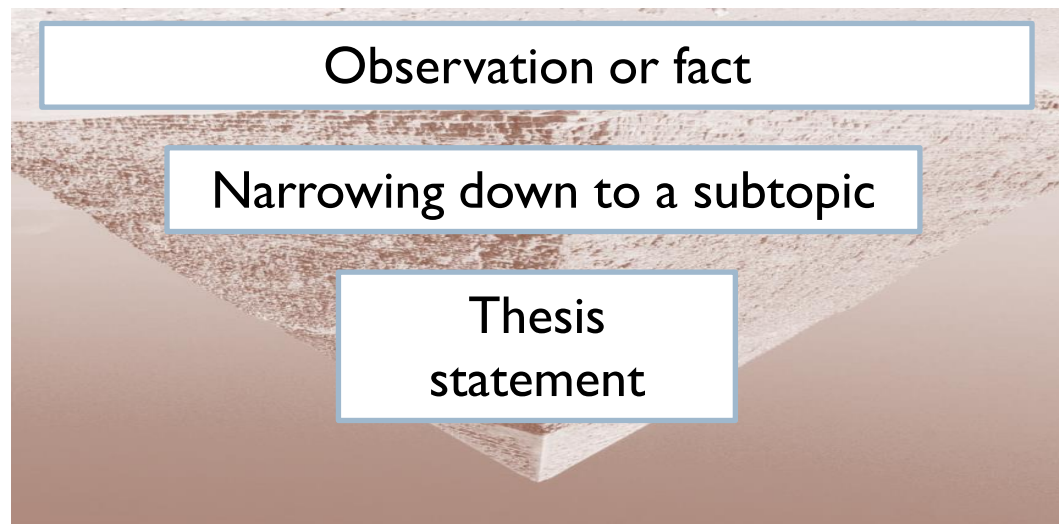


# Exercise - Thesis statement

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How would you introduce this thesis statement?

**This paper reviews recent research into the use of Facebook by university students.**





# Original introduction: does it work?

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## **Why students use Facebook**

The past decade has seen the rapid development of online social networks throughout the whole world. It is becoming increasingly difficult to ignore the influences these online social networks have on our everyday lives. One of these major online social networks is Facebook. Facebook was originally made for college students so that they would have a good way to communicate with their peers. However, over the past decade, not only have college students used it, but increasing numbers of older and younger people have implemented this social network into their daily routines as well. While there has been much research on the privacy matters of Facebook, there has been little empirical research into why people actually use Facebook. **This paper reviews recent research into the use of Facebook by university students.**

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# Original introduction

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## **Why students use Facebook**

The past decade has seen the rapid development of online social networks throughout the whole world. It is becoming increasingly difficult to ignore the influences these online social networks have on our everyday lives. One of these major online social networks is Facebook. Facebook was originally made for college students so that they would have a good way to communicate with their peers. However, over the past decade, not only have college students used it, but increasing numbers of older and younger people have implemented this social network into their daily routines as well. While there has been much research on the privacy matters of Facebook, there has been little empirical research into why people actually use Facebook. **This paper reviews recent research into the use of Facebook by university students.**

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# Original introduction: final two sentences

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## Why students use Facebook

The past decade has seen the rapid development of online social networks throughout the whole world. It is becoming increasingly difficult to ignore the influences these online social networks have on our everyday lives. One of these major online social networks is Facebook. Facebook was originally made for college students so that they would have a good way to communicate with their peers. However, over the past decade, not only have college students used it, but increasing numbers of older and younger people have implemented this social network into their daily routines as well. **While there has been much research on the privacy matters of Facebook, there has been little empirical research into why people actually use Facebook. This paper reviews recent research into the use of Facebook by university students.**

Problem/Research gap is defined

Thesis statement does nothing with this problem/gap



# Thesis statement

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- ▶ A thesis statement does for a text what a good topic sentence does for a paragraph: it guides the content and structure.

You could choose between three forms for the thesis statement:

- A question (What is the best solution?)
- Statement of aims (This essay discusses/outlines/examines...)
- A statement (The best solution is x)

For this course, we strongly recommend the use of the third option.

A required improvement is that your thesis statements become more precise.

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# Exercise – which thesis statement works best?

1. This essay outlines the arguments that are presented by both authors.
2. This essay aims to compare the extent to which Mody (2015) and Thompson (2016) share their points of view about the use of emoji's.
3. While Mody and Thompson both argue that emojis contribute to our written text, they have different opinions on how emojis are interpreted.
4. While both authors state that written text is our most powerful communication tool, Mody (2015) emphasizes that the use of emoji could lead to several communication problems whereas Thompson (2016) believes these icons are mainly enrichments to written text.
5. Both authors argue that emojis are an addition to our language, but they disagree in whether they have a positive or negative influence on our language.
6. Mody (2015) and Thompson (2016) both discuss the use of emojis and the effects of it.

# Exercise – which thesis statement works best?

1. This essay outlines the arguments that are presented

2. This essay aims to compare the extent to which Mody (2016) and Thompson (2016) share their points of view about the use of emojis

3. While Mody and Thompson both argue that emojis are a part of written text, they have different opinions on how emojis are used

4. While both authors state that written text is our main communication tool, Mody (2015) emphasizes that there are several communication problems whereas Thompson (2016) argues that emojis are mainly enrichments to written text.

5. Both authors argue that emojis are an addition to our language, but they disagree in whether they have a positive or negative influence on our language.

6. Mody (2015) and Thompson (2016) both discuss the use of emojis and the effects of it.

Number 4 is the most specific and in that sense best. However, the first part (what they agree on) is such an obvious statement that it doesn't really add something. It could be more concise. Number 5 would also be a good candidate if it's stated who's negative and who's positive.

Original introduction:

## **Successful industrial applications of formal methods**

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Formal methods are becoming more and more popular for software and hardware development in industrial projects. Formal methods are specific ways of developing systems in a mathematical defined and structured way. This makes it possible to formally prove that a specific property which is part of the specification exists in the developed system. One main reason for adopting the use of formal methods is that most industrial guidelines demand increasingly more safety guarantees, as is also the case in the railway industry [1-2]. In some cases, these safety guarantees simply cannot be made without using formal methods. Some of the many applications of formal methods that have been studied are railway signalling systems [1], automated metros [2] and aerospace systems [3].

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Original introduction:

## **Successful industrial applications of formal methods**

Formal methods are becoming more and more popular for software and hardware development in industrial projects. Formal methods are specific ways of developing systems in a mathematical defined and structured way. This makes it possible to formally prove that a specific property which is part of the specification exists in the developed system. One main reason for adopting the use of formal methods is that most industrial guidelines demand increasingly more safety guarantees, as is also the case in the railway industry [1-2]. In some cases, these safety guarantees simply cannot be made without using formal methods. Some of the many applications of formal methods that have been studied are railway signalling systems [1], automated metros [2] and aerospace systems [3]. **This paper aims to give an overview of several different successful industrial applications of formal methods and to explain why the adoption of formal methods has been so successful in these specific projects.**

# Finding articles for your assignments

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You need to base all of your assignments on 2-5 academic articles, and how they interact.

Find academic articles by...

1. ...checking the bibliographies of articles.
2. ...picking a journal and choosing two articles on the same topic
3. Use the article database on Canvas

Example journals:

- Journal of Software Engineering;
  - International Journal of Human Computer Interaction;
  - International Journal of Information Security.
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# Are your articles academic?

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- Who is/are the author(s)? Academics?
- Who is the audience ((general) public vs. other scholars)?
- Where was this published (academic journal)?
- Check the language, tone, and point of view of the article.
- What is the aim of the paper? Is the topic narrow enough? Does the article generate new knowledge?
- Look at the length and structure of the article.
- Look at the reference list and in-text citations. Is it clear which sources are used? Can you find some of the sources?

Useful links:

<https://bowvalleycollege.libguides.com/c.php?g=10229&p=52137>

<https://www.midmich.edu/student-resources/lis/library/find-articles/academic-articles>

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# Brainstorm:

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- a) What will be the main topic of your paper (what do your articles have in common?)
- b) Why is that topic relevant/important?
- c) What are the main differences between the articles? (If you haven't read the full articles yet, scan the abstracts for a few general points)



# Assignment I

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- ▶ Write your own 3-sentence introduction, based on the exploration of your topic so far.
  1. Use the first sentence to introduce the topic.
  2. Use the second sentence to explain why the topic is relevant or interesting.
  3. Use the third sentence to indicate what you want to say about the topic.

Upload this assignment to the appropriate window by Friday, 11 April at 23:59.

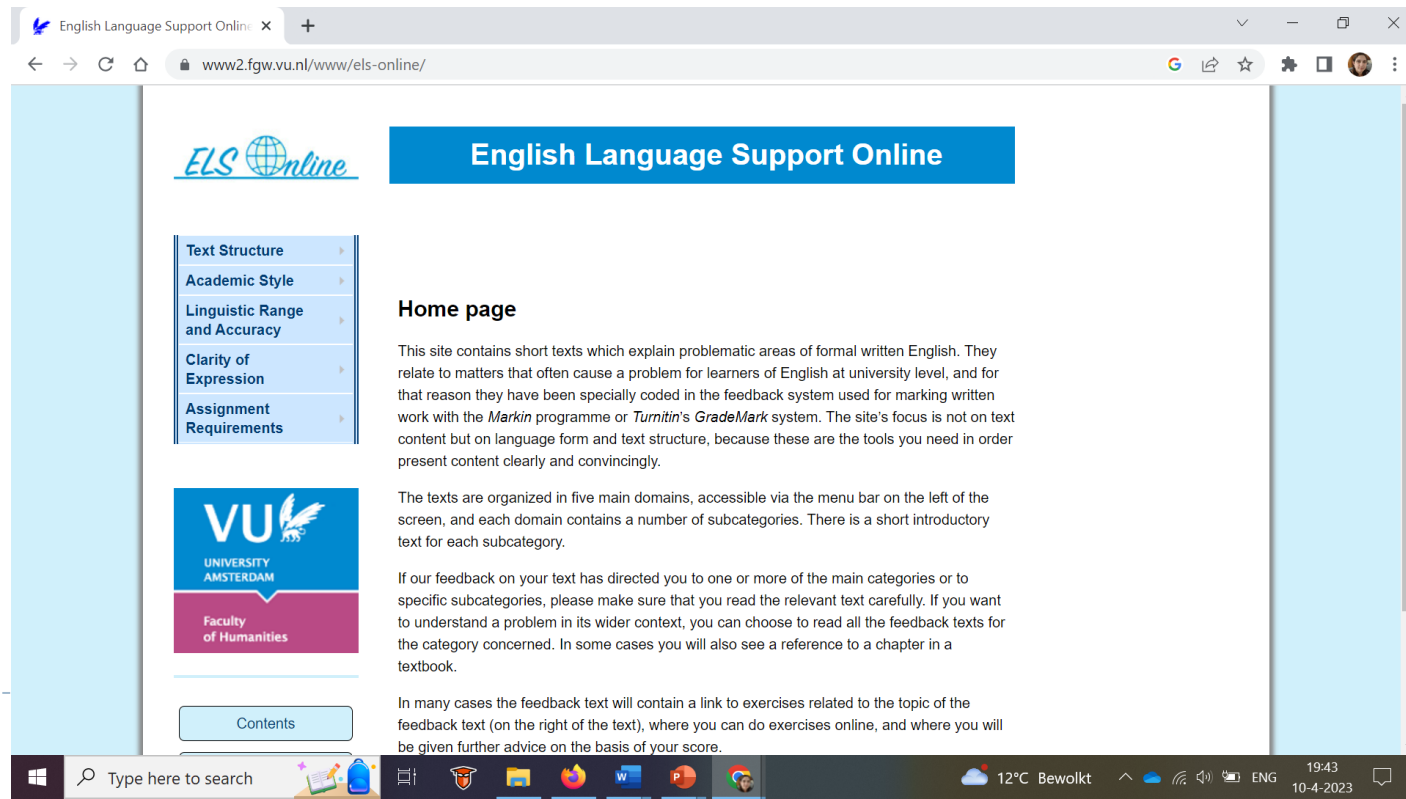


# Feedback document explanation

## English Language Support (ELS) online:

<https://www2.fgw.vu.nl/www/els-online/>

You need your VUnetID and password to log in!



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# Error Correction

See handout

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# Language correction tools

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## Grammarly: false identification of passive voice

Know that the start of any learning journey has **three main phases**: the very beginning, when we're filled with enthusiasm; the fall from Eden, when we realise the magnitude of our new venture; and the marriage, when we finally commit to developing competence regardless of the obstacles in our way and the difficulties that befall us.

### Passive voice

This sentence appears to be written in the passive voice.  
Consider writing in the active voice.

 [Learn more](#)



Grammarly has an aversion against passive voice. Here, “we’re filled” is falsely identified as a passive structure.

=> However, “filled” is an adjective here, not passive voice.



Source: <https://translatorstudio.co.uk/grammarly-pros-cons-limitations/>



# Grammar codes

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- ▶ ADV ADVERB [-ly; position]
- ▶ AGR AGREEMENT [the man are]
- ▶ ART ARTICLE [the / a]
- ▶ COLL COLLOCATION [word combinations]
- ▶ COMP COMPLEMENT [verbal structures after a verb or noun: \* he avoided to go]
- ▶ PREP PREPOSITION
- ▶ REL RELATIVE CLAUSE [who, that, which]
- ▶ SP SPELLING
- ▶ VB VERB FORM
- ▶ WO WORD ORDER



# Coming up next...

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Make sure to complete Assignment 1 (three-sentence intro) by Friday, 11 April before midnight!

